adultery; fought a vicious war against his own son and then forced the defeated youth to put on a bridle and saddle and crawl on the ground in humiliation; and pillaged and robbed the surrounding lands at will. Fearing a justly deserved hell, he had in his old age made a pilgrimage to Jerusalem, where he was rumored to have bitten off a piece of stone from the Holy Sepulchre with his own teeth so that he would have a relic to bring home.[3]

The current Count of Anjou, Fulk V, was more moderate than his ancestor, but no less ambitious. The marriage of his young son to the future queen of England was good for Matilda, since it brought the resources of France's most powerful region to her aid. It would also make Fulk's grandchildren into royalty. And it would give Anjou, in return, the protection of the English king.

Fulk V was in need of this protection for his son, because he was already planning to leave his home for another throne. In a pilgrimage to the Holy Land in 1120, he had befriended the king of Jerusalem, Baldwin II. Baldwin II had four daughters but no sons; he wanted to assure the succession of his oldest daughter, Melisande, to the throne of Jerusalem, and Fulk was a widower. As soon as he had arranged for the marriage of Geoffrey and Matilda, Fulk relinquished the title of Count of Anjou to his son and departed for Jerusalem. "Within a few days after his arrival in the kingdom," writes William of Tyre, who knew Fulk, "the king gave him his oldest daughter to wife." When Baldwin II died, in 1131, Fulk and Melisande were crowned king and queen of Jerusalem.[4]

Meanwhile, his son and new daughter-in-law had quarreled and separated.

Geoffrey had risen in the world, becoming count at a ridiculously young age; Matilda had sunk from empress to countess. Matilda, once married to the most powerful man in the west, had ruled Italy in her husband's absence; now she was tied to a teenager who had been knighted a bare week before the wedding. After a single year, she walked out on her child-groom and went home.

The cause of the quarrel is unknown (Simeon of Durham says that Geoffrey "repudiated" Matilda "without respect"), but eventually Matilda's father talked her into returning. The two must have worked out some way of coexisting; Matilda bore her young husband a son in 1133, when she was thirty-one and he was twenty, and then gave him two more in the next three years.[5]

In 1135, Henry I of England was in Normandy, his own land, visiting his daughter just across the border in Anjou. He had "delayed" his return to England, writes the English chronicler Henry of Huntingdon, "by reason of his great delight in his grandchildren." One day he returned from hunting and indulged himself in a dinner of lamprey eels: "of which he was fond,"